

THE OLYMPIC GAMES

In the rolling hills of the Greek countryside, beside a sacred grove of olive trees, lies Olympia, a sports ground dedicated to the god Zeus. Every four years from 776 BCE to 393 CE the Festival of Zeus was held here, accompanied by the Olympic Games, the cultural high point of the Greek calendar.



The athlete has his arm back, ready to swing it forward and release the discus.

This sculpture shows the strong, athletic physique valued by the ancient Greeks.

1 The stadium was where athletic events such as races and javelin throwing took place.



Birthplace of the Olympics

Olympia is in the Peloponnese region, in the south of mainland Greece. The site is located where two rivers meet, a short distance inland from the Ionian Sea.

2 The Hill of Kronos was covered with oak trees and olive trees, both sacred to Zeus.

Sporting ideals

Ancient Greece was made up of city-states that constantly fought each other. Most sports were based on the skills needed in war, such as speed and strength. The Greeks also prized beauty, discipline, and honor, and the Olympic Games celebrated all of these ideals. Athletes were often portrayed in sculptures, such as this discus thrower.

The glory of Zeus

The Greeks believed in gods and goddesses with a wide range of powers. The Olympic Games were held to honor Zeus, King of the Gods. He was also God of the Sky and Keeper of Oaths, responsible for order and justice.

